

[Lesson 34:](#) Faith in Every Footstep (See L34 [Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To help us understand how the pioneers' journey to the Salt Lake Valley parallels our journey back to our Heavenly Father and to help us appreciate the sacrifices made by the pioneers.

Elder M. Russell Ballard: Their "journeys parallel our own. There are lessons for us in every footstep they took—lessons of love, courage, commitment, devotion, and, most of all, faith." ("[You Have Nothing to Fear from the Journey](#)," Ensign, May 1997, 59)

1. The Lord instructed the Saints regarding their physical preparations for their journey.

Read "Winter Quarters" in *Our Heritage*, [pages 71-72](#).

"The Saints in Winter Quarters suffered much from sickness and other hardships, yet they continued working and making preparations for their journey." (*Lesson Manual*)

In what ways were they and others blessed for their continued determination?

How have you been blessed by persevering in a time of hardship?

How can persevering in a time of difficulty help those who come after us?

- D&C 136. Brigham received this revelation in January of 1847 at Winter Quarters.

How can each of the following instructions apply to each of us now?

- Read and discuss verses 2, 3, 5, 6, 8, and 10.

†1. Wallace Stegner †2. Leonard J. Arrington and Davis Bitton

2. The Lord instructed the Saints regarding their conduct.

- D&C 136:17-33. The Lord also "gave the Saints directions regarding spiritual matters" and their relationships. (*L.M.*)

What instructions did the Lord give the Saints about how they should conduct themselves?

- Read and discuss verses 19, 21, 23-24, 25-26, and 27.

- D&C 136:28. The "Lord gives instruction on appropriate recreation." (*L.M.*)

Elder David O. McKay: On "the plains, after a day's march, the wagons were drawn up in a circle, a man with the violin would take his place by the campfire and there on the prairie the sturdy Pioneers would join hands in a dance, opening it by prayer, and participate in amusement that fostered the spirit of the gospel. ... President Brigham Young ... once said, in substance: 'The atmosphere of the dance should be such that if any elder be called from the party to go to administer to a sick person, he could leave with the same spirit that he would go from his elders' quorum meeting'" (in Conference Report, [Apr. 1920, 117](#)).

How can we apply this counsel?

- D&C 136:32-33. What did the Lord instruct the Saints to do to learn wisdom?

In what ways have you found these instructions to be true in your life?

3. Under the direction of President Brigham Young, the Saints journeyed to the Salt Lake Valley.

"Two years before the Prophet Joseph Smith died, he prophesied that 'the Saints would continue to suffer much affliction and would be driven to the Rocky Mountains,' and that some of them would 'live to go and assist in making settlements and build cities and see the Saints become a mighty people in the midst of the Rocky Mountains.'" (*Teaching of the Prophet Joseph Smith*, sel. Joseph Fielding Smith [1976], 255) In fulfillment of this prophecy, some 70,000 Church members from all over the world made the trek to Utah between 1847 and 1869." (*Lesson Manual*)

†3. John Benson, Forty-niner †4. About Mary Ann Kennedy Bird (Charles, husband) †5. Elder M. Russell Ballard

†6. President James E. Faust †7. Elder M. Russell Ballard

Read *Our Heritage*, "The Brooklyn Saints," [pages 74-75](#); and "The Gathering Continues," [pages 75-76](#); and "This is the Right Place," [pages 76-77](#).

Next Week: L35: "A Mission of Saving"; See L35 [Class Member Study Guide](#).

(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#).) † •

†1. **Wallace Stegner:** “There are more than theological reasons for remembering the Mormon pioneers. They were the most systematic, organized, disciplined, and successful pioneers in our history. Where Oregon emigrants and Argonauts bound for the gold fields lost practically all their social cohesion en route, the Mormons moved like the hosts of Israel they thought themselves. Far from loosening their social organization, the trail perfected it.” (From the video: *Trail of Hope*)

†2. **Leonard J. Arrington and Davis Bitton:** “Historians have called the Mormon migration the best-organized movement of people in American history. Unlike other contemporary journeys to the Far West, it was religiously motivated. The Mormons went without guides and professional outfitters employed by most westering emigrants. A poverty-stricken band of people, in many cases unable to outfit themselves properly, the Saints were not frontiersmen; they were artisans, farmers, businessmen, and clerks. The organization and cohesion of the Mormons was in marked contrast to ‘the process of disruption that prevailed so generally’ in overland trail movements. Unique to the Mormons were the planting and building for the benefit of those to come later, sending back from Salt Lake City relief and supply parties to aid others on the last and toughest part of the route, and establishing a Perpetual Emigrating Fund to finance the poverty-stricken so that they could make the journey and pay later. The entire community of Nauvoo, a whole culture, was transported to a completely uninhabited location. Other frontier communities either grew slowly, adding a few families at a time until local government and trade became possible, or materialized overnight in the boom-bust syndrome of the mining exploitation of the West. In contrast, Salt Lake Valley was, within three months of settlement, home to nearly two thousand people and was well organized for trade and government.” (*Mormon Experience*, p101)

†3. **John Benson, Forty-niner:** “This was a great day for the people in this vicinity. They were celebrating the second anniversary of their entrance into the valley. An immense amount of work and energy had been expended in preparing for the celebration. It was estimated that six to eight thousand took dinner. I think two hundred emigrants took dinner with them. All were urged to sit in. I hesitated, but did so after two urgent invitations. The tables were spread with the greatest plenty, and in taste and quantity not to be excelled. As I walked away from the bower I turned and looked back. There were more people than I had seen since I left the Missouri river. Where did they come from? How did they get here? I pinched myself to make sure that I was

not dreaming. I have seen tables set for probably a hundred or more, but here were tables for thousands. How could they, in so short a time, with so small a beginning, have produced so much? It seems incredible. I take my hat off to those who planned and executed it.” (Opening from the video: *Trail of Hope*)

†4. **About Mary Ann Kennedy Bird:** “Mary Ann, after leaving her comfortable home in Hampton, New York, experienced the apostasy of the Kirtland era and at the same time was six months pregnant. She bore a child while destitute in the wilderness before reaching Nauvoo, bore three children at Nauvoo, one at Winter Quarters, one while crossing the plains at Council Point and another at Salt Lake City, Utah. That means that she bore children at or near every major church historical site during these periods of drivings and persecutions. She was pregnant and had a small family to care for during those times of serious trial when so many people ... left the Church. Mary Ann recalled having seen her home being burnt to the ground by the mobs four times during her life time as she was fleeing with her family for their lives. On one occasion, Charles and Mary Ann and their small family found themselves in the middle of the wilderness in the snow. They had to abandon their wagon containing all that they owned in this world. Mary Ann, pregnant, so over-extended herself in the care of her small family, that her toes on one foot became so seriously frost bitten that she had to have them amputated while in the wilderness and without anesthesia. When the Charles and Mary Ann Bird family eventually arrived in Salt Lake City, they had only the clothes on their backs as possessions, but were grateful to be alive.” (Her husband’s name was Charles. From a history of the Benjamin Freeman Bird family by Charles A. Stratton)

Recommended reading:

1. Elder M. Russell Ballard, “[You Have Nothing to Fear from the Journey](#),” *Ensign*, May 1997, 59.
2. Elder Dallin H. Oaks, “[Following the Pioneers](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1997.
3. Mary Ellen Smoot, “[Pioneer Shoes through the Ages](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1997.
4. Jennifer L. Lund, “[Pleasing to the Eyes of an Exile](#)”: The Latter-day Saint Sojourn at Winter Quarters, 1846-1848. This links to a description of the BYU Studies article and you can download a free pdf copy of the article if you like.

Visit stephenmbird.com

†5. **Elder M. Russell Ballard:** “Life isn’t always easy. At some point in our journey we may feel much as the pioneers did as they crossed Iowa—up to our knees in mud, forced to bury some of our dreams along the way. We all face rocky ridges, with the wind in our face and winter coming on too soon. Sometimes it seems as though there is no end to the dust that stings our eyes and clouds our vision. Sharp edges of despair and discouragement jut out of the terrain to slow our passage.... Occasionally we reach the top of one summit in life, as the pioneers did, only to see more mountain peaks ahead, higher and more challenging than the one we have just traversed. Tapping unseen reservoirs of faith and endurance, we, as did our forebears, inch ever forward toward that day when our voices can join with those of all pioneers who have endured in faith, singing, ‘All is well! All is well!’” (“[You Have Nothing to Fear from the Journey](#),” *Ensign*, May 1997, 61)

†6. **President James E. Faust:** “Faith in every future footstep will fulfill prophetic vision concerning the glorious destiny of this Church.” (“[Pioneers of the Future: ‘Be Not Afraid, Only Believe’](#)” *Ensign*, Nov. 1997, 42)

†7. **Elder M. Russell Ballard:** “We are the inheritors of a tremendous heritage. Now it is our privilege and responsibility to be part of the Restoration’s continuing drama, and there are great and heroic stories of faith to be written in our day. It will require every bit of our strength, wisdom, and energy to overcome the obstacles that will confront us. But even that will not be enough. We will learn as did our pioneer ancestors, that it is only in faith—*real* faith, whole-souled, tested and tried—that we will find safety and confidence as we walk our own perilous pathways through life.” (“[You Have Nothing to Fear from the Journey](#),” *Ensign*, May 1997, 61)

Further recommended reading:

1. [Nancy Jensen](#), “D&C Lesson #34 ...” at LDS Gospel Doctrine Plus, presents other successful rescue efforts of Saints behind the main body.
2. [William C. Beardall](#), “Lesson 34: Faith in Every Footstep,” presents a very fine outline of some of the major pioneer treks to Salt Lake Valley.

Visit stephenmbird.com

Recommended media:

1. Image: “[Mary Fielding and Joseph F. Smith Crossing the Plains](#)”.
2. Image: “[Winter Quarters](#)”.
3. Image: “[Death in the Martin Handcart Company](#)”.
4. Video: Elder Robert B. Hales: “[Learning Through Trials](#)” (2:29).
5. Video: President Dieter F. Uchtdorf: “[Faith Of Our Fathers](#)” (1:41).